



lingoda

Modality in focus: using *may*, *might* and *dare*

GRAMMAR

LEVEL
Advanced

NUMBER
EN_BE_3319G

LANGUAGE
English





Goals

- Can form a more complex sentence using the modal verbs 'may' and 'might' and use them to express permission, criticism and requests accurately.
- Can form a more complex sentence using the semi-modal verb 'dare' and use it to express assumptions, disapproval and offence accurately.





Might I suggest being on time for the lesson, given that you are the teacher, after all?

How dare you?!



Modality in focus: using **may**, **might** and **dare**

In this lesson you are going to learn more ways to use the verbs **may**, **might** and **dare**.



How dare you speak to me like that?



Review: *may* for permission

- We use **may** and **might** when talking about **permission**, but we much prefer **may**.
- Using **might** in place of **may** in these sentences would cause confusion, as it implies **possibility** rather than permission.

We may not enter that room, it is closed to the public.

You may take the rest of the day off.

He may not come to the wedding.

You may not talk to that man again.





Review: *may* and *might* for polite requests

- **May** and **might** are both **modal verbs** which **suggest possibility**.
- When making a **polite request**, we use **may** most often.
- In some cases we can use **might**, but it is very formal and can sound old fashioned.
- May and might are useful in **negotiations**, because they allow you to **politely disagree** and make **another suggestion or proposal**.

- **May/might** I make a suggestion?
- **May/might** I interject?
- **May/might** I explain that from my perspective?
- **May/might** I go over that again?





Polite criticism with *might*

- When we want to **criticise** someone we don't usually do it directly in English.
- We sometimes make a **rh~~etorical~~ question** with *might*.
- This is useful during a **negotiation**, when you want to express **disagreement**, but you do not want to come across as rude.

- **Might I suggest** that instead of...
- **Might it be better** to...
- **Mightn't it be better** to...





Fill in the gaps

Fill in the gaps with either may or might. Justify your choice. Both might be possible.

1. You may leave early if you have a doctor's note.
2. He still may/might come, it's only early after all.
3. May I ask for a short recess to consider the new evidence?
short recess - short break
4. May I take your plate?
5. We might / may not want to move forward on the deal until we know more about their financial situation.





Making requests

What requests might these people be making?

May I get the contract?



May I ask a question?



May I...?



May I order something?



May I have a minute because I have to look for something?

Might I...?



Practise negotiating with modal verbs

Practise negotiating the following proposals. Using the expressions you have learnt, politely disagree to the requests then provide an alternative solution.



May I suggest that instead of working from home, we introduce flexible working hours?

Your employee wants a promotion, but you do not think they are ready yet.

May I suggest that we meet in half a year to see if you have moved forward?

Your employees want to be able to work from home.

Your manager wants to hold a big meeting on Friday afternoon at 4pm.

May I suggest we hold the meeting today, instead of Friday afternoon?



Speculating about past actions

- We use both **may** and **might** to **speculate** about actions in the past.
- The structure is **may/might + have + past participle**.
- There is little difference between the two forms.

May	Might
They may have already arrived . I'll go and check.	He might have already finished his work. Let me go and see.
He may not have submitted the form yet. I can call and ask.	They might not have spoken to him yet. I don't want to spoil the surprise.
Her family may not have been as wealthy as those around her.	They might not have taken these statistics into account the last time something like this was planned.
She's late. She may have missed her flight.	You never know. He might not have spread the rumour himself.



Might... but...

concession - compromise

- In a **negotiation**, we often use the phrase **might... but...** when we want to make a **concession**, or add a **differing point of view** to the first phrase.
- This structure is useful for **reaching a compromise**.

- I might not have the most work experience, but I know I can bring a lot of passion to the team.
- Your offer might be viable in the short-term, but...
- It might seem like we are ripping you off, but...

ripping someone off - stealing an idea, work, or style
cheating someone by charging too much (money related)





Speculate about what might have happened in these situations

1. He's late again.



He might have got caught up in traffic.

2. Sales are declining.



Customers might not have signed contracts.

3. John has resigned from the company.



He might have been unhappy.

4. Alice still hasn't replied to my email.



She might not have read it.

5. Gloria was stuttering during her speech.



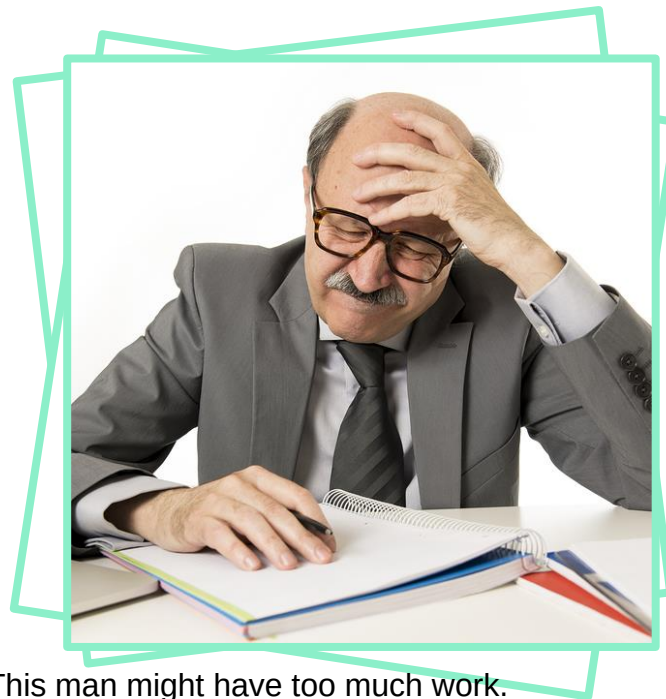
She might have been nervous.



Speculating

What's happened? Make speculations using may or might.

The two guys might have made decisions without talking to her.



This man might have too much work.



Complete the sentences

Complete these sentences so that they make sense.

1. Our product might be expensive, but... it lasts a long time. (it is very durable)

2. We might not have the largest revenue, but...we have a great customer base to survive in the future.

We might get the product late

3. ...but we can certainly try to deliver the product to you more quickly.

We might not be the most innovative company

4. ...but we certainly have a high customer satisfaction rate.

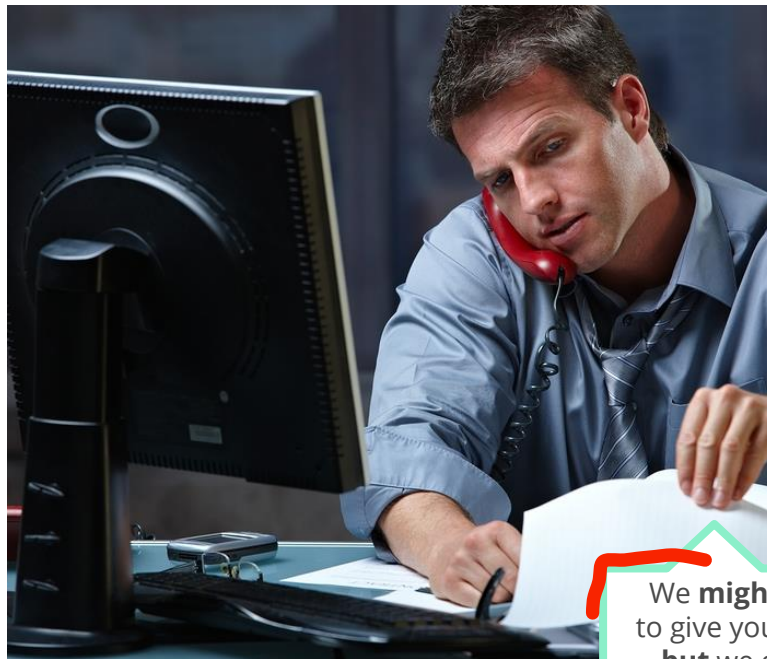
5. You may not want to invest in a start-up, but... you may support the other company.

you could support the other company.



Practise negotiating using *might... but...*

Imagine you are a salesperson. One of your customers is asking for a full refund on your product, but you are unwilling to concede. Using *might... but...* offer at least five alternative suggestions and try and reach a compromise.



We **might not** be able to give you a full refund, **but** we can certainly give you a discount on your next purchase.



The verb *to dare*

- **Dare** is a **semi-modal** verb.
- When it takes its **modal** form, it is not followed by **to** and **does not change** form in the **3rd person**.
- It is mostly used in **negative** and **interrogative** sentences. Look at the examples below for its use in the negative.

Negative	Interrogative
We dare not remain here.	Dare you remain in there?
She dare not tell her boss in case she gets fired.	Dare you tell him?
He dare not say it out loud in case of retribution.	Dare I tell my boss what I really think about this project?
I dare not bring it up again. He bit my head off last time.	Dare I bring up that awkward incident from last year?
They dare not arrive back late again. The manager is in a bad mood.	Dare we risk it?



Making assumptions

- We can also use **dare** to make **assumptions** or express a **probable truth**.
- We use **I dare say...**

I dare say he makes a lot of money, but he works hard enough.

Claire's been travelling all week – poor girl. I dare say she could do with a rest.

I dare say you've heard about her. She's infamous in these parts.

I dare say they'll come to the party. They've never been known to pass up free food.

That house hasn't been lived in for years. I dare say it could do with a spruce up.

spruce up - to clean, remodel, or paint (in regards to a house)

In American English instead of I dare say, we would use:

I guess...
I suppose...
I think...

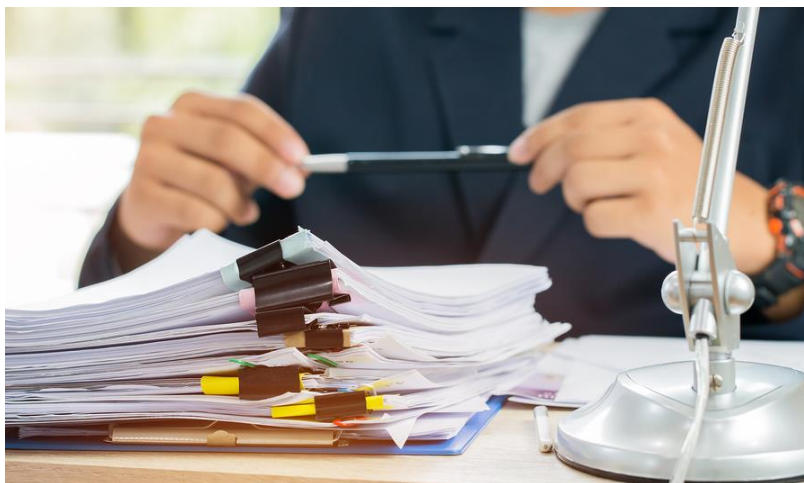




Dare I say it..?



- This phrase is used to express something shocking or controversial. It is an implied rhetorical question.



Dare I say it, but I found that report extremely dull.



Expressing disapproval or outrage

- In the **negative** or **interrogative**, **dare** can be used to express **disapproval** or **outrage**.
- It is often used as a **warning** for children in the negative.

Negative	Interrogative
Don't you dare speak to me like that.	How dare you speak to me like that?
Don't you dare walk out that door. We are not finished here.	How dare he even think of coming to my wedding after what he did?
Don't you dare tell me how to behave after what you did.	How dare she suggest that I'm incompetent?
Don't you dare eat another one of those biscuits.	How dare they just waltz in here like nothing happened?



Discuss

**Is there anything
you daren't do at
work?**



Use *I dare say* in response to these situations

1. You sent a neighbour a gift.



I dare say she'll send a thank you note.

2. Their daughter is getting married.



3. You don't know the answer to a question that's been bugging you.



4. Your friend has arrived after a long and tedious journey.



5. Your friend is short of money again.





How dare you?

What other situations can you think of when you might use the expressions *how dare you?* or *don't you dare?*





Write a letter using modal structures

Write a longer letter to an old colleague with whom you are very close. It should be informal in tone. Tell them how your week has been, using as many modal forms you have learned in this lesson as possible.

The letter should include the following:

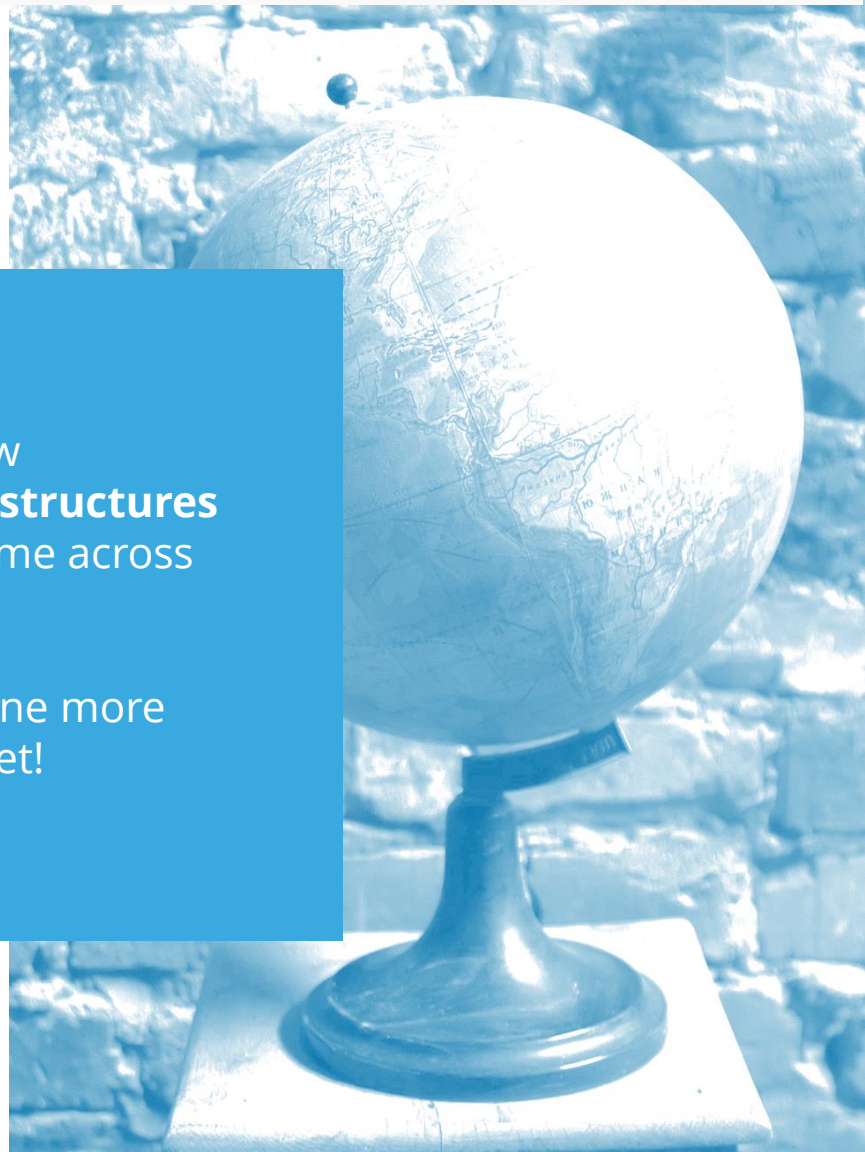
- **Explain how your week has been, including an unexpected change of plans (speculate about what might have happened) and someone who offended you or let you down.**
- **Give an opinion on something that might be controversial**
- **Ask for help with something**



Reflect on this lesson

Take a moment to review any new **vocabulary, phrases, language structures** or **grammar points** you have come across for the first time in this lesson.

Review them with your teacher one more time to make sure you don't forget!

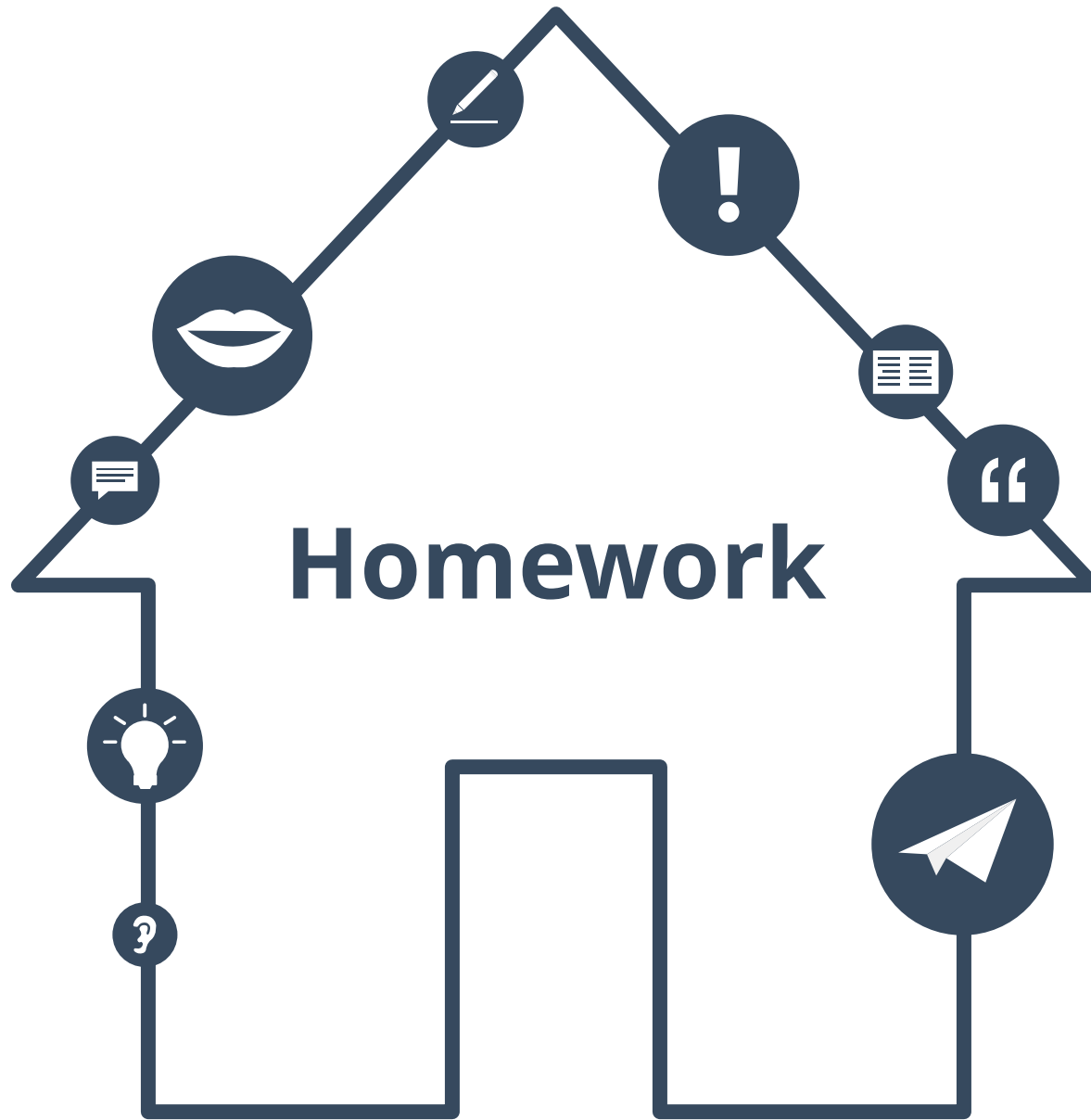




Answer key

Exercise p. 8

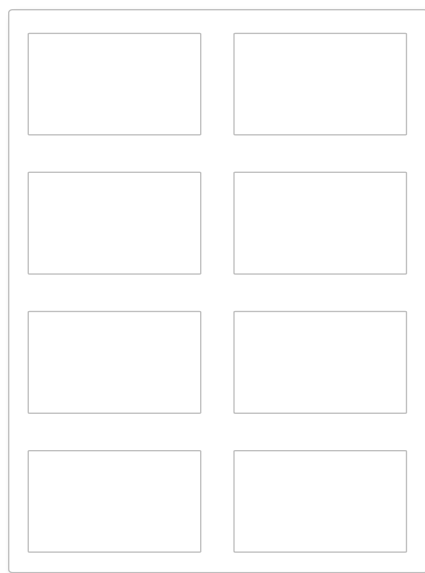
These answers are a guide - the student might justify a different answer.
1. May (permission), 2. might (probability), 3. might/may, 4. May, 5. might/may





Flashcards

Create flash cards for yourself with useful sentences and phrases from this lesson.





Fill in the gaps with an appropriate verb or verb phrase

1. I _____ he'll come, he usually tips up at these events.
2. He _____ not be able to come if his wife goes into labour.
3. She _____ not go out if she doesn't finish her homework.
4. How _____? I've just cleaned the floor and look what you've done!
5. I _____ talk to my parents the way you do, I think they'd kill me!





Homework

Exercise p. 29

Suggested answers: 1. I dare say, 2. might, 3. may, 4. dare you, 5. daren't



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